



GESS1025 Course Notes

Imagine Singapore in the next 50 years (National University of Singapore)



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Singapore and the World

- Singapore's 2 significant values:
 - **meritocracy**
 - **multiculturalism**
- National Identity is 1 type of social identity. It can be negative, but the goal is to establish a strong and healthy identity.
 - shared-ness (surface level vs. values)
- Racial and religious harmony starts with **respect**. It can be facilitated through a **common space** for people to come together.
 - Social policies are in place for racial harmony to happen - **it is not natural**.
 - Social harmony is actually very vulnerable.
 - Dealing with **intergroup differences**.
- Meritocracy is based on **demonstrated competencies**. (vs. **compassionate meritocracy**)
 - Presence of **unbalanced opportunities** that differ by family background.
 - The process must be fair. (vs. outcomes)
- Group Representation Constituency Concept, Forced Integration in Housing Policies, Admission policy for schools, Council of Minorities.
- Education Policies (implementation is the key strength)
 - Bilingualism
 - Streaming
 - Insistence on high standards and quality
- Factors that facilitated Singapore's change:
 - exceptional leaders
 - regional and international circumstances
- The global city: **Connectivity** is key.
- Success in leadership depends on **adaptation to context**.
- Singapore should continue to play its role quietly **behind the scenes**.
- Refugee and migrant issues: Singapore and the region need to find their own solutions for regional humanitarian problems.
- Foreign policies are mostly **transactional** in nature.

Reading: Perceptions of Meritocracy in Singapore: Inconsistencies, Contestations and Biases

by Terri-Anne Teo

The document, titled "Perceptions of Meritocracy in Singapore: Inconsistencies, Contestations and Biases" by Terri-Anne Teo, explores how meritocracy is perceived by Singaporean youths, particularly polytechnic students. The study challenges the widespread belief in Singapore that

meritocracy ensures socioeconomic mobility and ethnic equality. **It reveals a gap between the endorsement of meritocracy as a value and the conviction that it exists in practice.**

Key findings include:

1. Perceptions of Meritocracy: Most youths recognize meritocracy as a positive value. However, they also note its **differential functioning across groups, particularly disadvantaging ethnic minorities**. There's a notable discrepancy between the theoretical ideal of meritocracy and its practical implementation, especially in **employment practices**.
2. Cultural Stereotypes and Discrimination: The research highlights how **cultural stereotypes and ethnic discrimination are normalized** in society. Youths from minority groups are acutely aware of these biases, which often manifest in educational and workplace settings. These biases **impact their sense of self and opportunities**.
3. Ethnic Inequality in Practice: The study uncovers that while meritocracy is a central tenet in Singapore's socio-political landscape, in reality, **ethnic discrimination persists**. This contradiction suggests a misalignment between state-sponsored narratives of meritocracy and multiracialism and the lived experiences of Singaporeans.
4. State Narratives and Social Norms: The research also explores how state practices and social norms interplay, creating a complex understanding of meritocracy. It suggests that state narratives are not always internalized uniformly, leading to **varied perceptions and experiences of meritocracy among different ethnic groups**.
5. Policy Implications and Cultural Impacts: The findings call for a re-evaluation of policies and societal attitudes towards **cultural differences**. It emphasizes the need for greater equality and distribution of economic and political power, **acknowledging ethnic discrimination as a societal issue** requiring comprehensive redress.

In summary, the article provides a nuanced understanding of how meritocracy and multiracialism are perceived in Singapore, highlighting the inconsistencies between societal ideals and realities, particularly concerning ethnic minorities.

The document provides an extensive exploration of the **perceptions** of meritocracy among Singaporean youths, with particular emphasis on how it intersects with **ethnic and cultural biases**. The study is based on interviews with polytechnic students and reveals nuanced understandings of meritocracy, highlighting **discrepancies between its idealized conception and practical implementation**. Here are more detailed insights with examples:

1. Perceived Meritocracy vs. Reality: The majority of interviewees (76%) believed in the existence of meritocracy in Singapore, particularly in the education system. However, this belief is often contradicted by their later **admissions that ethnicity, class, gender, and sexuality can affect equal treatment in schools and the workplace**. For instance, an interviewee expressed that the Singaporean education system seems fair and offers a pathway for low-income individuals to rise to middle income through education. However, another interviewee noted that Malays and Indians are often stereotyped in media and society, which impacts their job opportunities.
2. Cultural Stereotypes and Discrimination: The study highlights the **prevalence of cultural stereotypes**, such as Malays being perceived as lazy and Indians as verbose. These stereotypes affect job opportunities, with some employers showing a preference for or

against certain ethnicities. For example, one interviewee mentioned that employers might prefer Chinese workers as they are seen as more trustworthy or hardworking, while Malays and Indians are stereotyped in certain roles.

3. The Impact of Ethnic Inequality: The research points out the contradiction of Singapore's meritocratic system in the face of evident **ethnic discrimination**. One Malay interviewee shared her experience during a job interview where she was asked about her lifestyle habits, a line of questioning not directed at her Chinese counterpart. This highlights the subtle forms of discrimination prevalent in the job market.
4. Individual Responsibility vs. Societal Change: A recurring theme is the emphasis on individual effort as a way to overcome ethnic discrimination. However, **this overlooks the need for systemic change**. For instance, one interviewee, a Malay, mentioned having to work harder to disprove stereotypes, reflecting an internalization of individual responsibility over societal or institutional change.
5. Normalization of Ethnic Discrimination: The study shows how ethnic discrimination is normalized and rationalized in Singaporean society, often under the **guise of cultural differences or economic necessities**. For example, the preference for Mandarin speakers in job opportunities is rationalized as a business need due to Singapore's ties with China, rather than being recognized as a form of ethnic discrimination.

In conclusion, the document provides a comprehensive analysis of the complex and often contradictory perceptions of meritocracy in Singapore. It uncovers the subtle ways in which **ethnic discrimination is interwoven in the fabric of Singaporean society**, challenging the widely held belief in the fairness and effectiveness of the meritocratic system.

Feedbacks

Clip 1. Introduction (Pang Eng Fong)

The construction of national identity can be accomplished through

1. Common language, history, culture, political ideals, ethnicity (France, Japan, China)
2. Lose immigrant identities, absorb dominant values (US)
3. Old cultures, sense of nationhood augmented after independence (Indonesia, India)

Singapore's major values – multiculturalism and meritocracy

1. What are the problems and costs of meritocracy? Does this bind or divide citizens?
2. Is "harmony" a **natural evolution or an outcome of laws and regulations and state intervention?**
3. Singapore citizens have **other group identities** based on their ethnicity, religion and culture. How should these identities be managed?

Clip 2. Interview with David Chang

Concept of national identity

1. National identity as one type of social identity and group membership
2. Factors shaping strength of national identity
3. National identity as positive and negative (e.g. common enemy against foreigners)

On Being Singaporean

1. Citizenship as legal status but also **emotive attachment**

2. **'Surface' sharedness** – Singlish; kiasu; food; etc.
3. **'Deep' sharedness** – Values that are collectively shared (non-corrupt, harmony, meritocracy, individual needs giving way to national needs)

Racial and Religious Harmony

1. **Toleration vs. Respect** and appreciation of religious beliefs
2. Construction and evolution of a **common space**
3. Equality accorded amongst all groups and the subscription of such beliefs
4. Social policies on harmony: **OB markers as 'volatile' and 'sensitive'**

Meritocracy

1. Divergent conceptions of meritocracy – demonstrated competence; not inheritance
2. **Unequal opportunities and starting points**
3. Compassionate meritocracy – levelling opportunities

Clip 3. Interview with Zainal Abidin Rashid

On Racial Integration

1. Different conditions of Muslim communities, particularly those forming minorities experiencing social change
2. Different experiences, given evolving globalised context
3. No effective existing model of harmony and living together
4. Policies – GRCs; housing policies; quotas for Malays in schools (mooted by Malay MPs); Council of Minorities; self-help groups (Any problems with this?)
5. Factors that threaten multiculturalism: **Regional and global race relations**

Clip 4. Interview with Gopinathan

Educational System and Policies

1. Colonial period – language/dialect based schools; missionary schools
2. Instrumentalist role of education through **use of English to bridge gaps** and internationalisation
3. Insistence of high standards and quality; investment of education and resources in Singapore
4. Limitations of bilingual and streaming/ranking processes?
5. Problems with policy implementation

Clip 5. Forum Discussion

4 students from SMU from different backgrounds (French; mixed-parentage; Malay; and Chinese spending a large part of his formative years in Mexico) discussing construction of self and national identity construction

Clip 6. Introduction (Pang Eng Fong)

Foreign Policies and Singapore in the World

1. China-Taiwan relations/meeting and Singapore as arbitrator and 'neutral' party
2. Singapore-US relations

Questions

1. How did Singapore play its outsized role in regional and global politics?
2. What are the principles of Singapore's foreign policy?
3. What are the strategies to ensure Singapore's survival in the region/world?

Clip 7. Interview with Kwa Chong Guan

Singapore's Metamorphosis

1. Factors contributing to success: exceptional leaders and regional and international circumstances
2. Singapore's positioning as global city – what kind?
3. Greater importance on the regional stage (ASEAN)
4. Singapore's outsized role in spite of smallness and lack of hinterland

Clip 8. Interview with SR Nathan

Changing Portfolios

1. Experiences and challenges as an early public administrator: changing problems; limited experience; unpredictability
2. Konfrontasi challenge

Clip 9. Interview with Kishore Mahbubhani

Attributes of Pioneer Leaders

1. Rajaratnam as early and powerful diplomat: Cuba Experience
2. 6 'Cs' of leadership: compassion, collector of talent, courage, dealing with complexity, cunning, and appreciating context
3. Role of small states vs. geopolitical incompetence of West for peacekeeping

Clip 10. Interview with Janet Lim

Observations about Singapore

1. Greater social consciousness among younger citizens, but lacks global consciousness and humanitarian needs globally (e.g. refugee situations)
2. Singapore's lack of engagement for humanitarian causes (other than natural disasters) in spite of its capacity
3. Reconceptualising 'refugees' and the instrumental benefits that states can glean from to manage such issues

Clip 11. Forum Discussion

2 students discussing and appraising foreign policies in Singapore and its reputation as a small nation-state (Nick and Damien)

Population

- Examine issues related to **fertility, morbidity, mortality, and migration**.
- Growth in the world population poses a serious challenge to the environment.
- The decline of the working population is another pertinent issue that affects the **dependency ratio**.
- Population indicators in Singapore:
 - fertility,
 - aging,
 - migration.
- From the 1970s to the 1980s, Singapore focused on export-oriented approaches which meant that Singapore had to **supplement the shortage of manpower with labor migration**.
- Singapore is very reliant on its human resources, thus low fertility rates pose a national crisis to us.
 - Rural vs. urban areas

- A low total fertility rate is a common issue across all developed countries but Singapore, **being a nation-state**, is extremely vulnerable to its repercussions.
- Expansion of higher education delayed entry into the workforce and family formation
- A high fertility rate is needed to support the growth and maintenance of the potential labor force, provide a foundation for military capability, and sustain consumption.
- Younger generations **have many options** and other aspirations than just family formation.
 - pull towards career aspirations
 - advancement of women
- The government offers incentives for marriage and procreation but is fighting against **rewards for paid work**.
 - draw of paid work: working to make ends meet, adequacy of income, economic power, social power, negotiation power
 - power of interjection to agency
 - a lifestyle we aspire towards
 - **challenges in getting women to form families while remaining in the workforce**
 - intensive parenting
- This issue is magnified in Singapore because the country is so small.
- Returns to a successful career vs. returns to a family (occurs during the third and fourth age).
- Family formation is important but it is **acceptable to delay** it in exchange for career opportunities.
- We bear the misconception that technological advancements have overcome the biological clock for women.
- **Principle of eugenics.**
- The three measures used for providing a holistic picture of aging in Singapore are **life expectancy at birth, life expectancy at age 65, and total fertility rate**.
- Critical implications of a growing aging population:
 - declining old-age support ratio (dependency ratio),
 - increasing tax and economic burden on the working-age population,
 - higher national healthcare expenditure (affordability and accessibility).
- Non-communicable health diseases will be a major health burden.
- Economic implications in terms of **shrinking working population and weaker competitiveness**.
- The pension system and healthcare system are also major concerns.
- A **successful aging** society will require the establishment of **harmonious relationships** among different generations.
 - **Provide dignity and affordable life** to the aged population (quality of life).
- Singapore attracts immigrants to promote economic growth.
 - This will result in increasing social and cultural diversity.
 - There is a need to address multiculturalism issues and increase social diversity while maintaining a strong national identity.

- However, there are several concerns about whether the **infrastructure** in Singapore is able to support this rapid growth in population.
- This will also increase the competition for jobs (economic).
- Aspirations.
- To resolve the issue of human capital.

Reading: Population problems, family policies and the naturalization of differentiated deservedness

Youyenn Teo

The document "Topic 2: Teo You Yenn" examines Singapore's population and family policies, focusing on the interplay of **public policy, personal choices, and social norms**. Key aspects of this document include:

- **Reaction to Population Policy:** In 2013, the Singapore government's White Paper projected an increase in population to 6.9 million by 2030. This was met with negative reactions, with **concerns about the negative effects of immigration, favoritism towards certain migrants, high living costs, crowded infrastructure, and erosion of Singaporean identity**. These responses were significant, marking challenges to the government's dominance and reflecting a desire to protect 'core' Singaporeans.
- **Differentiated Deservedness:** The document discusses the concept of 'differentiated deservedness,' where access to public goods like housing, healthcare, and education is contingent on conforming to certain social categories and practices, such as **family form**.
- **Gender and Class Inflections in Fertility Policies:** Historically, Singapore's policies have treated women's fertility as a problem, with a focus on their reproductive choices. This approach **differentiated women along class and ethnoracial lines, prioritizing high-educated women for childbirth and criticizing them for marrying late or having fewer children**.
- **Marriage, Housing, and Employment:** Singapore's policies closely link marriage, housing, and employment. Public housing (HDB flats) is a key area where this link is manifested, with regulations **favoring married couples and creating a context where marriage is incentivized and its dissolution made costly**.
- **Support for Narrow Familial Forms:** The state's attention to increasing fertility rates has led to policies favoring certain women, particularly those in **higher socio-economic positions**. These policies have resulted in a **privatized approach** to childcare, relying heavily on foreign domestic workers and grandparent caregivers, while childcare centers have been under-supported.
- **Cultural and Social Perceptions:** Singaporeans, influenced by policies, have developed complex scripts about **marriage, housing, and employment**. There's a naturalization of the link between these aspects, with a strong emphasis on romance in marriage and an acceptance of the differentiated access to housing based on marital status.
- **Individualism in a Communitarian Society:** Despite perceiving issues like care for dependents as public problems, Singaporeans tend to view their dilemmas as private

ones. There is a **strong emphasis on autonomy and responsibility within individual families**, with less expectation or desire for government intervention in childcare or elderly care.

- Citizenship and Rights: The document also explores the implications of these policies for citizenship and rights, noting that they foster a form of governance that emphasizes individual responsibility and self-reliance, often **overlooking the need for collective rights and shared responsibilities**. This has reinforced inequalities along gender and class lines, limiting the conception of citizenship rights.

In summary, the document critically examines the **impacts of Singapore's population and family policies**, highlighting how they shape individual behaviors, societal norms, and the concept of citizenship, often leading to inequalities and an emphasis on **individual responsibility over collective welfare**.

The document "Topic 2: Teo You Yenn" delves into the complexities of Singapore's population and family policies through a **Foucauldian and feminist lens**. It highlights how these policies, while aimed at addressing demographic issues, end up deeply shaping Singaporean identity, habits, and practices in a way that **emphasizes individual responsibility and self-reliance**, often at the expense of broader social responsibilities and rights.

- Governmentality and Individualism: The document employs Foucauldian concepts to describe how Singaporeans are governed through the production of **idealized identities, habits, and practices rather than just through repression**. This approach shapes how citizens view family formation, responsibilities, and the role of welfare, emphasizing self-reliance over collective welfare.
- Differentiated Deservedness: The concept of 'differentiated deservedness' in Singaporean policy articulates that access to key public goods like healthcare, education, housing, and childcare support is contingent upon one's **employment history, gender, marital status, and familial relationships**. This approach reinforces societal norms and delineates who is considered more 'deserving' of state support based on these factors.
- Gendered and Class-based Inequalities: The document also draws on feminist scholarship to discuss how policies, while claiming to be neutral, often **rely on and reinforce gendered and racialized assumptions about citizens**. This leads to solidified inequalities, with policies differentiating 'deserving' and 'undeserving' citizens based on their adherence to idealized familial and social roles.
- Self-Regulation and Citizenship: The state's population policies, despite their limited effect on marriage trends and fertility rates, have profound impacts on how Singaporeans **perceive themselves and their relationship to society**. These policies promote a narrow range of 'normal' behaviors and lifestyles, rewarding those who conform and disadvantaging those who do not. This framework of governance encourages self-regulation among citizens, aligning with the state's goals.
- Implications for Rights and Democratic Participation: The document suggests that the emphasis on individual challenges and self-reliance in policy-making limits the conception of citizenship rights. Instead of fostering a sense of collective responsibility and shared obligations, policies push towards an individualized understanding of

citizenship, where the **family unit is viewed as an independent entity responsible for its own well-being**, rather than part of a larger social fabric that deserves collective support and care.

In essence, the document provides a critical analysis of how Singapore's population and family policies, while addressing demographic issues, end up reinforcing individual responsibility, gender, and class-based inequalities, and a **narrow conception of citizenship** that prioritizes self-reliance and conformity to idealized social norms.

Feedbacks

Clip 1. Introduction (Noorman Abdullah)

- The wider goal of the module is to demonstrate that changes in **fertility, morbidity, mortality and migration** have significantly affected Singapore and other industrialised nations globally
- An appreciation and understanding of these dynamics in Singapore and the relationship to broader societal arrangements is especially pertinent as **different social institutions, policy makers and individuals grapple with and manage the demands and challenges of a rapidly changing and diverse population**
- Changing patterns in the global population are key areas many governments throughout the world have also been preoccupied with the “population problem” or “demographic crisis”
- These concerns are primarily because there are (a) significant challenges to the environment which is now threatened by the **unfavourable effects of industrialisation in the developing world**; and (b) the decline of the working population and the **costs of an ageing population or the dependency ratio** in many developed industrialised nationstates.

Clip 2. Demographic Characteristics (Noorman Abdullah)

- In Singapore, this current “population problem” is situated in a milieu of **delayed marriage, delayed childbirth and below-replacement fertility rates**.
- More recently, the Singapore state has emphasised the further problem of a balance between a “core” citizen and a “foreign” population

Clips 3 to 4. Fertility Issues (Noorman Abdullah)

- Different indicators of fertility measured through (1) crude birth rate; (2) total fertility rate; and (3) replacement level fertility.
- **Significant fall in TFRs** in many industrialised countries worldwide including Asian contexts and Singapore
- Importance of fertility issues for the state: (1) a high fertility rate will be able to support the growth and maintenance of the potential labour force to sustain economic growth of countries. More specifically, it **replaces the working population**; (2) it provides the foundation for the military and **military capability** through the replacement of young males (and females); and (3) a young population is also important in **sustaining consumption**

Clip. 5 to 7 Interview with Paulin Straughan

The interview focused on the reasons for falling TFRs in Singapore and the critical

implications on this demographic pattern and encouragement of family formation.

These may include:

1. Attraction to and rewards of paid work
2. Gender (women especially) and social transformation
3. Perception of personal “choices”
4. The expansion of **higher education opportunities** while important and welcome in many industrialised economies, has also **delayed entry into the workforce** and subsequently **family formation**

Clip 8. Reasons for low TFRs (Noorman Abdullah)

Reasons for low TFRs in developed nation-states:

1. the increase in **urban living**;
2. the decline of agricultural employment;
3. the availability of low-cost contraceptives and acceptance of **family planning**;
4. the **rise in female** education and their engagement in the formal labour market

In Singapore’s context, there was a shift from anti-natalist to pro-natalist policies, with strong **eugenics** undertones. These demonstrate state intervention and institutionalisation pertaining to population issues. Fertility privileges and disadvantages were largely attached to women; with little compulsion on men.

Clip 9. Introduction to Ageing Issues (Noorman Abdullah)

- By 2050, approximately one out of every four residents will be an elderly resident and the category of “old-old” (85 years and above), are increasing at a faster pace, **given falling TFR**
- Aged population will be healthier and more ambulant, better educated, have more access to financial resources, and more likely to engage in social and economic initiatives. A larger number will be single, female and living alone, or with small families.
- Three important measures provide a more holistic picture of ageing in Singapore, namely – **(1) expectancy of life at birth; (2) life expectancy at 65; and (3) total fertility rate**
- People are **living longer** as a result of several reasons: declining early childhood mortality; control of infections; better living conditions; improved diet and nutrition; better chronic disease management; medical and technological advances; and better quality of life.

Clip 10. Interview with Qiushi Feng

- Broad patterns pertaining to ageing population globally - except for Africa, world is ageing rapidly and will become a major transformation; **health patterns will change** (burden on non-communicable disease).
- Critical and significant implications to Singapore, but population ageing escalating in the future
- Factors shaping rising ageing issue: increased life expectancy, low TFR, immigration.

Conclusion (for Ageing)

1. Low fertility rates and an increasing ageing population means there exists an **old age dependency burden in Singapore**
2. A declining old-age support ratio points toward an **increasing tax** and economic burden on the working-age population

3. While the elderly population has previously been constructed as a “burden” and “problem”, this **discourse has shifted** over the course of time
4. **Financial adequacy and employment** are pivotal issues that affect the elderly

Clip 11. Introduction to Migration Issues (Noorman Abdullah)

- The Singapore state has often tapped on migrants from different backgrounds to **fill the workforce gap and augment economic productivity**, given Singapore’s “population problem”, though it has tightened its immigration framework since late-2009.
- Such patterns in international labour migration and the intake of PRs and new citizens through the globalisation of economies results in **increasing social and cultural diversity**.
- Strong concerns amongst Singapore citizens in regard to the accelerating stride of population growth: congestion on Singapore’s transport systems; tight housing market; lack of development and enhancement of supporting infrastructure; increased competition for jobs (especially for PMETs); growing income inequality; and other anxieties.
- Debate and frustration from Population White Paper

Clip 12. Interview with Kelvin Low

- Broad patterns for migration globally and Singapore – different streams of migrant flows (skilled/unskilled workers, students, etc.)
- **Key challenges and concerns** about migration and policy formulation in Singapore, and the ways to address these issues

Clip 5. Conclusion (Noorman Abdullah)

- Population issues and management of these are central to state legitimacy and political power
- Changing patterns in population have **significant implications for economic growth**, in addition to the fact that modern governments typically ground their legitimacy in economic performance
- Policy alternatives to address these challenges

Singapore’s Economy

Macroeconomics

Overview of Economic Development

- Singapore stands out for its **trade performance**.
- It also faces enormous challenges due to its **lack of natural resources** as well as **limited land and manpower**.
- Establishing Singapore as a **regional and global hub**.
- As Singapore moves forward, **local enterprises** will have a larger role to play.
- Foreign Direct Investment is viewed as a **package with management, technology, branding, distribution, and processes**.

- Investments have shifted from **manufacturing to services** in the past decade (from low-value to high-value activities).
- Singapore also embarked upon an active **export-promoted strategy**.
- INTRACO (international trading companies) allowed Singapore to trade by providing an outlet for Singapore's products to the global market **without involving itself in political aspects**. In addition, it facilitates Singapore's connection to the global economy.
- Recently, there has been more emphasis on **high-value exports** such as high tech and a shift in policy towards focusing on labor market outcomes.

Labour Market Issues

- The transformation that the labor market has undergone in terms of participation, education, and income for work.
 - labor force participation rate (LFPR) - women and elderly
 - proportion of degree holders among the employees in a certain age group
 - manufacturing vs. services
 - nominal income growth has slowed in recent years in conjunction with higher inflation resulting in a **decrease in real income growth**
- The tripartite approach to labor market relations (government, employers, union).
 - **progressive wage model** (wage, skills career, productivity)
 - **workfare income supplements** (low-wage workers) altering incentives
 - **address workers' needs**
- Outlook for the labor market.
 - reliance on foreign manpower
 - local hiring will not last

Productivity and Innovation

- Productivity **improves standards of living by increasing income**.
- There is a need for Singapore to continue innovations in exploring new forms of production and **creating new markets given our limited manpower**.
- As a country that focused on trade, **cost competitiveness was the main concern** for policymakers.
- Wage rises are an essential part of an advancing economy but to justify them, **productivity gains must be made**. However, this must be done to ensure that there is **no compromise on gains in income**.
- Innovation is the **transformation of capacity**.
- **Failure management** is a part of innovation.
- R&D expenditure, patent application, value of high-tech exports.
- Singapore leverages **MNCs' global production network** and exports due to its stability, connectivity, location, and security.

Microeconomics

- Basic public finance trade-off.
- Taxes cost society more than they raise as they **discourage productive behavior** (deadweight loss).
- GST is a consumption tax that is **regressive**.
- Transfer - GST voucher can offset GST.
- **Efficiency vs. Equity.**
- Minimum wage law, negative income tax (WIS).
- Pay-as-you-go pension system vs. funded or defined contribution schemes (CPF).
 - contribution rate
 - interest rate
- Retirement Sum.
- CPF contribution is **heavily invested in housing** instead of retirement.
- Targetted welfare for the elderly: **Pioneer Generation Package, Silver Support Scheme**.
- Life expectancy continues to rise in tandem with the standards and cost of living.
- Open market value.
- **Accurate congestion pricing** is the most efficient way to balance demand for driving with congestion problems.
- Inequality to access to public roads.

Reading: Hard Choices Challenging the Singapore Consensus

Donald Low and Sudhir Thomas Vadaketh

"Hard Choices: Challenging the Singapore Consensus" by Sudhir Thomas Vadaketh and Donald Low critically examines the prevailing economic and social policies in Singapore, particularly focusing on the **issue of income inequality**. The book deconstructs four central myths underpinning the Singapore government's approach to inequality:

1. Myth #1: Inequality is Necessary for Economic Dynamism and Competitiveness: This myth suggests that inequality is an inevitable consequence of rapid economic growth and is necessary for competitiveness. It argues that unequal rewards drive individual effort and enterprise, while policies that **reduce inequality decrease work incentives**.
2. Myth #2: Helping the Rich Helps the Poor: This is based on the belief that economic growth, primarily driven by the rich, **eventually benefits everyone**, including the poor. It assumes that wealth creation by the affluent leads to better economic conditions for all.
3. Myth #3: Inequality is Acceptable if Extreme Poverty is Addressed: This myth posits that as long as **everyone's income is rising** and extreme poverty is addressed through targeted measures, income inequality is not a significant concern.
4. Myth #4: Pay is Tied to Ability, Reflecting Differences in Productivity: This belief asserts that income disparities are a result of **varying levels of productivity and ability among individuals**, and that any attempt to reduce these disparities would lead to inefficiency.

The authors critique these myths by presenting evidence and arguments that question their validity. They highlight the importance of considering not only economic growth but also **income distribution, social equity, and the overall well-being of citizens**. The book urges a reevaluation of Singapore's economic policies and calls for more progressive and inclusive approaches to address inequality and social welfare.

"Hard Choices: Challenging the Singapore Consensus" delves into the first myth that inequality is necessary for economic dynamism and competitiveness. This myth asserts that rising inequality is an **inevitable consequence of rapid economic growth** and a condition for economic competitiveness, with the idea that unequal rewards drive individual effort and enterprise. However, the authors challenge this by providing examples and evidence:

- **Global Trends and Policies:** The collapse of unions in the United States, immigration in wealthy countries bringing low-wage competition, and the reduction in corporate and personal income tax rates in many countries are cited as factors that have accentuated inequality. Despite these trends, there is little evidence that countries with higher inequality perform better economically or that more equal countries face a significant economic cost in terms of competitiveness.
- **Economic Growth and Income Inequality:** The book posits that economic growth is a complex process **involving various factors like technology, policy, and institutions**. It's not clear that a country's income inequality is significantly correlated with economic growth or competitiveness. The authors suggest that governments should consider **other well-being indicators** like consumption, health, leisure time, and income distribution, alongside GDP growth.
- **Utilitarian View on Redistribution:** The authors argue that **conventional economics does not place distributive concerns secondary to growth objectives**. From a utilitarian perspective, since an additional dollar is worth more to a poor person than to a rich person, growth in incomes should benefit the poor. Increasing inequality is shown to negatively impact society's well-being, including increasing crime rates, which affects everyone, not just the poor.
- **Impact of Policies on Inequality:** The book discusses how policies in the rich world, especially in the US and Britain, have reduced the state's redistributive role. Examples include tax cuts for the rich, reduced social welfare spending, financial deregulation, weakened unions, and dismantled trade barriers. These policies have led to a significant rise in income inequality, with the US reaching levels comparable to some Latin American countries.
- **Singapore's Experience:** In Singapore, the increase in income inequality in the last decade raises concerns about whether the state has become less redistributive when its redistribution functions are most needed. The authors note changes in Singapore's tax system, like reduced corporate and personal income taxes and an increase in the Goods and Services Tax (GST), a regressive tax, that may have **contributed to rising income inequality**.

These examples and analyses aim to challenge the myth that inequality is a necessary component of economic dynamism and competitiveness, suggesting that more inclusive and equitable policies could lead to better outcomes for society as a whole.

The authors of "Hard Choices: Challenging the Singapore Consensus" debunk several myths regarding inequality in Singapore through a combination of theoretical analysis and empirical evidence. Here's a summary of how they address each myth:

Myth 1: Inequality is Necessary for Economic Dynamism and Competitiveness

Debunking: The authors argue that rising inequality isn't a necessary condition for economic growth or competitiveness. They provide evidence that countries with less social welfare spending, like the U.S., are not necessarily richer than those with more comprehensive welfare systems. They also challenge the notion that Europe's fiscal issues are due to overly generous social welfare systems, pointing out that countries facing severe fiscal problems aren't known for generous welfare systems, while those with strong social provisions like Germany and the Nordic countries have sound fiscal balances.

Myth 2: Helping the Rich Helps the Poor (Trickle-Down Economics)

Debunking: The authors contend that policies favoring the rich have not consistently led to economic growth that benefits the poor. Historical data show that in many developed countries, periods of higher growth often coincided with more robust social safety nets and progressive taxation. They also highlight that the increase in income inequality in Singapore over the last decade hasn't been accompanied by proportionate gains for the lower-income groups.

Myth 3: Inequality is Acceptable if There is No Extreme Poverty and Incomes are Rising Overall

Debunking: The book argues that inequality matters beyond absolute income levels, emphasizing the psychological and social effects of relative income and inequality. It challenges the notion that only extreme poverty needs addressing, pointing out the importance of how income is distributed and its impact on social mobility and the overall well-being of society.

Myth 4: Pay is Tied to Ability, and Rising Inequality Reflects Differences in People's Abilities

Debunking: The authors question the direct correlation between pay and productivity, especially in the context of Singapore's education system, which should have narrowed productivity differentials. They suggest that other factors, like immigration policies, play a significant role in determining wages and inequality.

In conclusion, the book argues that these myths prevent a comprehensive assessment of policy alternatives and limit the Singapore government's ability to address inequality effectively. The authors advocate for policies that balance economic growth with social equity and emphasize the importance of well-designed social welfare programs that encourage work and redistribute income without diminishing investment incentives

Feedbacks

Clip. 1 Introduction (Randolph Tan)

- Deals with Singapore's overall economy, using panel data from 3 sources
- Interview with economists, policy analysts and unionists
- 3 broad issues: overview of Singapore's economic development; **Singapore's labour issues; innovation and productivity, and challenges to Singapore's economy**

Clip 2. Overview of Singapore's Economic Development (Randolph Tan)

- Sets foundation for subsequent discussions, presentation of country profile, and regional and international comparisons; and strategies for development and foreign direct investment to stimulate Singapore's economic transformation
- Small physical size and population; high population density and urbanization; **excels in trade performance** (based on GDP), despite its lack of natural resources, land and labour
- Brief interviews with Lim Chong Yah (about economic growth); Manu Bhaskaran (growth model unique to Singapore); and Faizal Yahya (export strategy and role of INTRACO)
- Success in economic performance linked to **environmental factors and government policies** to promote economic growth (context is therefore important)
- Growth rates slower with no exponential growth today, given how growth is closely affected by external influence, but this is unsurprising in mature economies like Singapore
- Growth led to **increase in living standards** (increase in GNI per capita – leap of 42 times between 1965 to 2014) and comparatively with PPP (Purchasing Power Parity, taking into account inflation)
- Globally competitive, but challenges come from **newly emerging economies and global economic changes**.
- Growth model in Singapore linked to multinational/foreign investment centred model and Singapore's focus as a regional and global hub
- Importance of FDI given limited domestic market and massive unemployment and lowskilled workers: played important role not necessarily for the money, but the overall package of management, business process, distribution power, technology and branding brought by FDI – which acted as a **shortcut to growth**
- Incentives for FDI present very early in its history and current global competition for FDIs: investments and manufacturing facilities – and eventual creation of jobs (FDIs later **increased for services industry** – finance, insurance, etc. at the expense of manufacturing in Singapore)
- Growth in exports in Singapore; and role of INTRACO (International Trading Company) in global trade strategy charting a path for Singapore to go global – outlet for Singapore's products for the global market, including socialist economies (state-owned enterprises), without any **political involvement**.
- Exports and growth **overtaken** by other economies (e.g. Equatorial Guinea after discovery of oil reserves in 1990s), though still higher than major Asia Pacific economies
- Move away from textile manufacturing to electronics and wafer fabrication (high value of high-tech exports)

Clip 3. Singapore's Labour Force (Randolph Tan)

- Labour as primary resource for Singapore and challenges from **manpower limitations**
- Labour market transformation – participation, education and income from work
- Tripartite approach in labour market relations (businesses, unions, state)
- Outlook for labour market (especially in relation to slower workforce growth)
- Small resident workforce due to **demographic shifts** (older workers and increase in female participation saw labour force rates continued to sustain its increase)
- Education profile of labour force: **better education today** (degree holders making the highest proportion in labour force today), with **female resident workforce being more educated than male**
- Rise in service sector with decline in manufacturing – by 2014, manufacturing dropped to 11.9%; and services rose to 82.3% and construction fell to 4.7%
- **Nominal income growth slowed** in recent years while inflation relatively higher (compared to period 1983-1994)
- Labour movement promoted progressive wage model (PWM) and schemes such as Workfare to manage wages (PWM: Wages are not only important but also career, skills and productivity ladder)
- Interviews with K. Karthikeyan (about PWM and tripartism) and Lim Chong Yah (tripartism)
- Tripartism in Singapore: **economic growth with equity; minimize industrial disputes; and promote good symbiotic relationship** – goal to achieve maximum employment of workers
- Consistently high employment (only at 6.8% during recession period) but **reliance on foreign labour** to meet increasing demand for manpower, since resident labour is insufficient

Clip 4. Labour Costs and Productivity (Randolph Tan)

- Productivity improvements translate into **higher standards of living** – Wage increases essential in any advancing economy but if wages increase without commensurate rise on productivity, **cost competitiveness** will be reduced
- Growth with a heavy reliance on **manpower accumulation** cannot be sustained
- To remain globally competitive, continued innovations in exploring new forms of production and creating new markets are necessary
- Increase in unit labour cost alone do not necessarily point to a lack of competitiveness
- Focus to strengthen productivity and keep costs in check, without compromising on gains in income
- Interview with Manu Bhaskaran and Faizal Yahya (on productivity): transformation of capacity – early development focused on productivity – and increase in productivity can allow employers to provide higher income since companies will still be able to profit
- Innovation became more important from the 90s; failure being a key component of innovation and creativity (R&D)
- Strategies to sustain Singapore's technological and competitive edge (**patent applications** lower in Singapore) – e.g. innovation in scientific instruments, pharmaceuticals, computers, electrical, and aerospace

Clip 5. Public Finance – Comparative Taxes (Walter Theseira)

- Strong fiscal policy since independence – Singapore government spending about 12% of GDP; government revenues were 17.8% of GDP (in other countries, government spending exceeds revenues considerably)
- Deficits or surpluses are not inherently “bad” or “good”, but rather **what and how revenue is being spent on, and the consequences of such fiscal policies in the short and long run**, given that paying for public services (expenditure) are costly
- At the same time, higher taxes (according to Theseira) discourage productive behaviour/economic activity – **deadweight losses** (represents the real economic costs of taxation such as companies moving or reducing workers because of higher taxes)
- Spreading taxes across different sectors is more efficient than relying solely on one source of revenue
- Controversial source of revenue: GST – consumption tax (constituting about 16% of total government operating revenue) [raised more than personal income tax, but less than corporate income tax]
- **Consumption taxes are regressive** – placing higher rate of tax and burden on low-income groups – since they spend a larger portion of their income on consumption
- Argument that consumption tax should exclude necessities – but are all items necessities – and can benefit the rich more than the poor?
- Singapore’s model: **redistribution** through government transfers (which could cancel out most, or all, of the consumption taxes paid) e.g. GST voucher

Clip 6. Public Finance – Wages and Income Transfers (Walter Theseira)

- Large income inequality exists in the modern market economy where states have institutionalised different measures to reduce this
- Income inequality as a challenge – how do we address about jobs which command low wages, which are lower than the national median (S\$3,770)?
- Different factors affecting wages – **supply and demand; and level of value and productivity of job; simple skillsets**
- Option 1: minimum-wage laws (e.g. Australia) but could **increase unemployment** for low income workers because of higher wages (though could recalibrate minimum-wage laws depending on type of workers, age and other criteria)
- Option 2: Top-up on salary (or negative income tax) with the state supplementing income instead of taxing (through government transfers such as Workfare Income Supplement in 2007 – to incentivize work – where it pays up to a certain amount depending on salary earned). Any inherent problems with such assumptions?

Clip 7. Economics of Ageing – Life Cycle (Walter Theseira)

- Aged population – consume more than produce – and that money required then must come from the period when we are productive and earning income (as working adults)(Think critically – consider section on ageing in Population)
- Some countries adopt **public pension systems** to avoid reliance on children for income (such as pay-as-you-go schemes, where taxes from current working adults are paid to aged population)
- Others adopt a funded or defined **contribution scheme**, where a portion of money is invested as working adults and returned upon retirement (e.g. CPF)

- Two systems have **different implications for demographic changes** (e.g. ratio of working age may be less than aged population)

Clip 8. Economics of Ageing – Retirement Adequacy (Walter Theseira)

- Meeting the “**retirement sum**” – the amount of money expected to need at retirement to provide basic standard of living during retirement years (S\$155,000 in 2014, increasing over time because of rising life expectancy and higher cost of living)
- 2 key parameters – contribution rate to CPF and interest rate/rate of return
- Economic growth in Singapore will be less than it was a rapidly industrialising economy, thereby affecting tax burdens on the working adults when engaged with a pay-as-you-go system
- CPF schemes have shifted over time from simple retirement savings scheme to a social investment scheme. **Heavy investment for housing through CPF**, which also meant reduction in retirement savings

Clip 9. Transport Economics – Private Transport Policy (Walter Theseira)

- High costs of cars – and large price differences between other countries – linked to taxes and additional fees
- COEs and vehicle quota system – willingness to pay tied to ability to own a car – and other contexts (such as a lottery)
- Controversial system of car ownership but there exists important **hidden costs of unregulated car ownership**: congestion, which affects productivity and costs; vehicle emissions; lost businesses; etc.
- Road-pricing and congestion pricing to balance demands for driving

Security Threats

- “Security in an **objective** sense, measures the absence of threats to **acquired values**, in a **subjective** sense, the absence of fear that such values will be attacked.” Arnold Wolfers.
- Singapore security is greatly disadvantaged by its **small size** and further made vulnerable by its **dependence on food and other resources from external sources**.
- There is a **strong correlation between the defence and economy** of Singapore.
- **Poisoned shrimp -> porcupine -> dolphin.**
- There was a need for Singapore to remain **adaptable** and **relevant** to bigger powers to stay afloat (active, constructive, and relevant international player).
- National security vs Human security (Non-traditional security threats).
- **Diplomacy** is a pillar of Singapore national defence. The other one is **deterrence**. They are used to promote and protect its core interest.
- Singapore’s economic well-being relied heavily on **global connectivity**.
- Food security can be partially mitigated through **diversification** of sources and suppliers.
- ASEAN diplomacy is not always about enhancing cooperation, it is also about **managing frictions and disputes**. It is also a platform where all 10 SEA countries conduct important interaction with the Dialogue Partner countries.
- Singapore helped the newer ASEAN countries to narrow the development gaps.

Food Security

- DFI supply chain: Supplier -> Shipping line -> Dry / Fresh conventional DC -> flow through DC -> stores
- Tech enabled supply chain: demand forecasting, replenishment and inventory optimization
- Cross Agency Collaboration: DFI + SFA + Enterprise Singapore
- Inbound and outbound operations
- Multiple sourcing for fresh chickens, substitutes
- Stockpile.
- Lock price.

Reading: Singapore in the Malay World. Building and breaching regional bridges.

Lily Zubaidah Rahim

The document titled "Topic 4: Rahim" provides a comprehensive analysis of Singapore's national security and foreign policy, emphasizing the **influence of a deep-rooted insecurity and a realist worldview on its strategic culture**. Here's a summary with elaboration on the examples provided:

- **Insecurity and National Identity:** Singapore's national identity is profoundly shaped by its **struggle for survival and security**, accentuated by its predominantly Chinese population in a region with larger Malay states. Historical events like the separation from Malaysia, dependence on neighbours for essentials, and regional ethno-nationalist sentiments have fostered a culture of insecurity. This has justified high defence spending and compulsory military service, underpinning the People's Action Party (PAP) government's authoritarian stance. Examples include the National Day parades, which prominently feature military and security services, and the exclusion of Malay men from military service, reflecting institutional discrimination.
- **Realist Worldview of an Authoritarian State:** Singapore's security policies are driven by a **realist perspective, prioritizing state security over international or human security**. This perspective has led to controversial alliances with repressive regimes like Suharto's Indonesia and Burma's SPDC, driven by economic and strategic interests. An example is Singapore's significant investment and defence ties with the Burmese military regime, despite its human rights abuses.
- **Realist Technocracy:** The PAP leadership, including figures like Lee Kuan Yew and Lee Hsien Loong, has maintained a realist foreign policy. Their influence is seen in the **infusion of military personnel into key governmental and academic positions**, promoting a realist security narrative that goes largely unchallenged due to the authoritarian political environment and limited public debate on security issues.
- **Realist Notions of Sovereignty:** Singapore's aggressive posture towards neighbours arises from its perception of a threat to its sovereignty, particularly from Malaysia and

Indonesia. This has led to **heightened military preparedness and instances of diplomatic tension**, like the dispute over military bases with Malaysia post-separation.

- Regional Security Dilemma: Singapore's military build-up, partly driven by fears of aggression from neighbouring countries, has contributed to a regional arms race. The perceived need for military superiority has led to **significant investments in advanced technology and compulsory military service**.
- Singapore-Malaysia Security Counter-Balance: The relationship between Singapore and Malaysia is marked by **mutual suspicion and attempts at military balancing**, reflecting their historical tensions and differing perceptions of regional security.
- Racialised Security Apparatus: Singapore's security strategy, including its military policies, has been influenced by **racial dynamics**, with implications for its Malay population.
- Siege Mentality States in Collusion: Singapore and Israel share similarities in their security approaches, driven by a **siege mentality**. Both rely on the US for security support and have developed advanced military capabilities. This alignment has occasionally **strained Singapore's relations with its Muslim-majority neighbours**.
- Realist Realignments: Singapore's foreign policy has shifted over time, aligning closely with Western powers, particularly the USA. This alignment is driven by strategic and economic interests, as well as a **desire for security guarantees from a powerful patron**.
- Support for the Iraq War: Singapore's strong alliance with the US is exemplified by its support for the Iraq War, which stands in contrast to the more cautious stance of other Southeast Asian countries. This support is part of a broader strategy to **maintain US security presence in the region**.
- Support for the Fictitious Case for Invasion: Singapore's foreign policy decisions, such as its support for the US-led invasion of Iraq, have been guided by its realist perspective, **prioritising national security and strategic alliances over ethical considerations**.

These examples illustrate Singapore's complex interplay of national identity, security concerns, and foreign policy decisions within a realist framework, shaped by historical, regional, and global factors.

The document "Topic 4: Rahim" provides an in-depth analysis of Singapore's national security strategy and foreign policy, highlighting the country's approach to regional and international relations. It elaborates on various aspects, including Singapore's military buildup, relationships with neighboring countries, and its alignment with Western powers, particularly the United States. Here are further details on the examples and points discussed in the document:

- Regional Security Dilemma: Singapore's rapid military buildup post-separation in 1965 was driven by **fear of a Malaysian-instigated coup**. The country has since maintained high defense spending, significantly more than its Southeast Asian neighbors. Examples include the acquisition of advanced technology, like fighter aircraft capable of striking targets up to 1000 miles away, illustrating the extent of Singapore's military preparedness.
- Singapore-Malaysia Security Counter-Balance: Tensions between Singapore and Malaysia have led to a **competitive arms buildup**. For example, Singapore's

preemptive strike strategy, including the possibility of invading Johor in a bilateral military conflict, has fueled arms races and heightened suspicions between the two nations.

- Racialized Security Apparatus: The exclusion of Malays from full integration into the Singapore Armed Forces (SAF) reflects the country's **ethno-nationalist strategic culture**. This exclusion has been attributed to perceptions of potential conflicts with Malaysia and Indonesia. The discriminatory practices in the SAF have contributed to **regional apprehensions and internal ethnic tensions within Singapore**.
- Siege Mentality States in Collusion: Singapore is often compared to Israel in its security approach, with both countries relying heavily on the US for security support. Singapore's military strategy, similar to Israel's, is offensive in orientation and aimed at preemptive strikes against potential threats. The collaboration with Israel has been a significant aspect of Singapore's military development.
- Realist Realignments: Singapore's foreign policy has seen a shift from a non-aligned stance to a **pro-Western and US orientation**. This shift was evident after the British military withdrawal from the region, with Singapore actively courting the US to maintain a visible security presence in East Asia. Examples include Singapore's support of US military operations in Vietnam and the establishment of US military facilities in Singapore.
- All the Way with the USA: The relationship between the People's Action Party (PAP) leadership and US administrations, particularly the Republican Presidents like Reagan and Bush, has been notably close. Singapore has consistently supported American security interests, including providing logistical assistance for US military operations and serving as a rest and recreation base for US troops.
- Uncritical Support for the Iraq War: Singapore's unreserved support for the US-led invasion of Iraq in 2003 contrasts with the more cautious stance of other Southeast Asian countries. The country's alignment with the US included providing military facilities and intelligence support. This support has been viewed with suspicion by some neighboring countries.
- Support for the Fictitious Case for Invasion: Singapore's support for the US-led invasion of Iraq was based on the Bush administration's narrative, despite global suspicions about the underlying motives for the invasion, such as controlling Iraq's oil reserves and US geostrategic interests.
- Short Term Benefits and Long-Term Costs: Singapore's support for the US in Iraq included providing military facilities and sending troops for rebuilding missions. This support led to benefits like the US-Singapore Free Trade Agreement but also strained relations with neighboring Muslim countries and **heightened regional tensions**, especially regarding Singapore's close ties with the US and Israel.
- Soft Power Deficit and Vulnerability in the War on Terror: The PAP government's approach to the 'war on terror' has been marked by a **focus on hard power and security-oriented policies, often at the expense of addressing root causes and socio-political factors driving Islamic militancy**. This approach has led to heightened security measures and strained relations with regional countries.

Conclusion: The document concludes that Singapore's security paradigm, heavily influenced by **fear and the perception of threats**, has led to a significant military buildup and close ties with the US and Israel. However, this approach has also contributed to regional insecurities and strained relations with neighboring countries. The document advocates for a **new security paradigm that incorporates human security considerations and ethical engagement transcending state boundaries**. These detailed examples from the document illustrate the complexities of Singapore's security strategy and its impact on regional dynamics and international relations.

Feedbacks

Clip. 1 Introduction (Tan See Seng)

- How long can Singapore's success be sustained? Is Singapore's success at risk and how does Singapore remain a cohesive society and profit from a stable economy?
- Lectures appraise effective ways to manage threats and risks in Singapore that is linked to Singapore's stability
- Lectures also address the risks Singapore faced in the past 50 years and the threats it could potentially face and the broader implications and management of security risks
- What is security (i.e. **absence of threat to the state and dominant common acquired values/beliefs** – A. Wolfers) and how this is made sense of – objective vs. subjective conception of threat?
- There may not be a real objective threat but the fact that it may **potentially exist** would pre-empt states to formulate particular security policies

Clip 2. Defining Singapore's Security (Tan See Seng)

- Singapore's security considerations, external factors affecting Singapore's security, how Singapore manages risks and security, and future risks which would affect Singapore
- Singapore's geography and strategic position as **favourable**, but also given **smallness and lack of resources**, Singapore is exposed to vulnerabilities, limits size of defence force, overreliance on basic necessities and resources externally, and lacks strategic depth
- **National interests – sovereignty (internal and external); territorial integrity (covering land, sea and airspace); social stability (in relation to potential faultlines); and economic wellbeing – constitute vital parts of the nation**
- Strong **correlation between defence and economy of Singapore** (ability to purchase equipment rests on economic resources; and FDI and MNCs confidence to establish its business in Singapore is tied to Singapore's safety and stability)
- Singapore's core interests have not shifted dramatically, but substance and style of governance and foreign policies have been recalibrated to broader global changes
- Changing definitions of security and threats, and the strategies adopted

Clip 3. Regional Dynamics and Singapore's Security (Tan See Seng)

- Singapore's national interests and strategic culture have been shaped by historical events in the past 50 years
- Security risks after WWII saw conflicts between different nation blocs with clashes **ideologically, politically and strategically** (e.g. the Cold War, Korean War 1950-53;

- Vietnam War 1965-73 where US and Soviet Union attempted to work through their proxies to achieve their dominance and contain each other)
- In such a climate Singapore adopted to be **non-aligned** i.e. did not commit to take sides on either camp but would engage in both when their interests were aligned
- Issues during pre-independence: period of attempting to **contain communism; student protests; strikes; Konfrontasi**; etc.
- Issues after independence: Vietnam War (**domino theory** that if Vietnam were to fall to communism, the rest of SEA would follow suit); British withdrawal of troops in 1968; formation of ASEAN as a collective voice against external forces and to promote regional peace (1967); Communist Vietnam invasion of Cambodia; etc.
- Building a conscripted force and military and acquisition of arms/ammunition
- Support to US as a counterweight to Sino-Soviet influence to communist threat in Indo-China (1975)

Interview: Background of Vietnam's invasion of Cambodia (Barry Desker)

- (a) Strength of communist countries in SEA; Vietnamese boat refugee influx; more cohesive ASEAN from 1976-78; period of Cold War; etc.
- (b) Shaped Singapore's **security paradigm** making fundamental changes to bilateral relations
- (c) Creation of insecurity because of its small size to stand up to larger states
- (d) Fear that this could lead to takeover of other states in SEA because of the perception of Vietnamese strength and size
- (e) Principles of sovereignty could be potentially violated
- (f) Role Singapore played – in diplomatic struggle – and uphold legitimacy of Cambodian state and not to recognize Vietnam's occupation and control of Cambodia (as well as lobbying support in the UN)

Clip 4. Rise of Unconventional Threats (Tan See Seng)

- Fall of Berlin Wall and collapse of USSR saw the end of Cold War saw **US as sole superpower** and global policeman who was able to exert its economic and strategic power (Bush's "new world order" – US intervention in Iraq when it invaded Kuwait)
- Facilitated economic development of the region; saw rise of China and rapid economic growth (though raised concerns among small states) and **economic dependence on China**
- Singapore's friendly relations with India, China and other states
- Rise of non-traditional security risks after 2001 which saw rise in **transnational terrorism, natural disasters, cyberattacks, pandemics, pollution, climate change**, etc. – with threats on humans rather than states, and which can transcend territories/boundaries
- Distinction between national security and human security: former makes states the object of security; human security focuses on protection of individuals
- Threats may come from non-state actors such as terrorist groups – attack on Afghanistan and Iraq (2003); Philippines and Indonesia as targets of terrorist attacks and guerilla war from separatist groups; etc.

Interview: Singapore's choices after 9/11 and Iraq invasion (Bilahari Kausikan)

- (a) Participation in US-led invasion to Iraq to the extent that no Singaporean lives would be at risk – interest was to **support US bilateral relationships and cohesion** in Singapore
- (b) Considered Iraq's attempts as a terrorist attack and that basic security in Singapore rested with the US
- (c) Dealing with transnational terrorist threats (border controls, resilience, beef up anti-terror activities, surveillance, preparedness, etc.); and coping with aftermath of potential attacks
- (d) New terrorist groups formed (e.g. ISIS, base in SEA, etc.)
- (e) Role of Malay-Muslim community and state intervention of "deviant" religious preachers; education of non-Muslims; the role of the distorted versions of Islam
- **Other non-traditional security threats** – natural disasters (and destruction and loss of lives): other than haze, Singapore is sheltered from disasters; financial crises (Asian financial crisis which raised tensions within SEA; global 2008 economic crisis; etc.); SARS pandemic, swine flu, bird flu outbreaks, etc.; lack of basic necessities like disruption to water and food supplies; cyberattacks and cybersecurity in banking, defence, health, etc.

Clip 5. Managing Threats in Singapore

- **Deterrence and diplomacy** to promote and protect its core interests
- Professional armed forces would not be practical – and the building of NS and racially diverse population would foster national harmony and cohesiveness
- **Force multiplier** – refers to any capability when added to and employed by the defence force would significantly increase the combat potential of that force and enhances the potential for successful mission accomplishment (e.g. purchase of advanced defence weaponry/technology that makes deterrence possible; building armed force; etc.)
- Defence budget increase as no option as it faces new threats and that small countries often overlooked as irrelevant
- Singapore's attempts may at times not be fully appreciated regionally and globally (e.g. Singapore as a "free-rider"; regional responses of Singapore leap-frogging and abandoning ASEAN; etc.)
- Singapore's relationship with China in **establishing economic partnerships** and government-to-government projects
- On the security front Singapore has supported US presence in the Asia-Pacific region to advance its own core interests
- Lee Hsien Loong (LHL) (2015): Singapore must continue to be an **active, relevant and constructive international player and maintain its credible presence**; and work to shape its agendas for its own benefit (and leadership with international governance groups, international discussions and key roles in making common cause with other states which shares Singapore's predicaments).
- LHL: Singapore's contribution to **regional stability** through its involvement with ASEAN and making common cause with neighbours; narrowing development gap in such ASEAN countries, working on economic integration and transboundary haze –also about managing tensions and friction, and as a role as a broker

Interview (Ong Keng Yong)

- (a) Importance of ASEAN and region to Singapore's security

- (b) Small island surrounded by big countries; and SEA as a unique geographical advantageous location (and the amount of trade)
- (c) As member of ASEAN speaking to the world (with its dialogue partners and cooperation/engagement) would give **Singapore weight and credibility**; and developing a unique forum to exchange ideas/issues, etc. on sectorial issues
- (d) Singapore's contribution to ASEAN (e.g. economic and security arenas) in contributing and translation of ideas into initiatives, and internationalising the grouping
 - Singapore's defence **diplomacy**: defence cooperations with other countries; sending defence attaches; conducting dialogues and joint bilateral or multilateral military exercises; conducting military exchanges; military aid; etc.
 - 1984: Singapore establishing "Total Defence" (economic defence; social defence; psychological defence; etc.) to involve every Singaporean to secure itself; and National Security framework formed (**Military, Civil, Economic, Social, Digital and Psychological Defence**)

Clip 6. Conclusion (Tan See Seng)

- Changing character of warfare requires recalibration of strategies with strong defence and to wield influence in Singapore (and defend itself militarily); and the vulnerability of Singapore
- **Singapore's core interests circulate around ideas about having peace in the world; establishing a network of friends and allies; and preservation of Singapore's sovereignty**

Diversity, Integration & Liveability

- Migration usually has **push and pull factors**.
- **Vagabonds** move involuntarily while **tourists** move because they want to.
- Four models of migration:
 - classical - economic migrants,
 - colonial,
 - guest-worker,
 - illegal.
- Theories of assimilation:
 - classical model - merging identity,
 - racial or ethnic disadvantage model,
 - segmented assimilation model - social economic status.
- **Racial is a social construct and has social power**. In contemporary society, race is decided visually.
- Megacities are cities with more than 10 million people.
- As the population density of a city increases, the liveability decreases?
- Liveable cities are cities with a **competitive economy, high quality of life, and sustainable environment**.
- To develop and sustain a liveable city there are two levers:
 - planning and development that is both integrated and long-term,
 - governance that is pragmatic and visionary.

Reading: Foreigners in Our Homes: Linking Migration and Family Policies in Singapore

Youyenn Teo and Nicola Piper

"Topic 5: Teo and Piper" explores the complex relationship between migration and family policies in Singapore, focusing on the treatment of foreign domestic workers (FDWs). Here's a summary, with additional details on the examples and points made in the document:

- Singapore's Migration Policies and FDWs: Despite high state intervention in foreign labor management, the conditions of FDWs are mostly **left to employers' discretion**. This has led to injustices and occasional abuse.
- State's Reticence and Employers' Reluctance: The government's reluctance to enact significant legislative changes for FDWs is puzzling. The analysis goes beyond migration policies, suggesting that changes need to consider Singapore's broader social policies and the ideal of the 'Singapore family'.
- Global Trends and Local Context: The document discusses the global trend of importing migrant care labor due to declining fertility and ageing populations. It also addresses the developmentalist state's role in shaping labor supply and the difficult conditions endemic to domestic work.
- State-Society Relations and Migration Policies: The paper argues that Singapore is concerned with more than economics in its migration policies, reflecting broader societal approaches.
- Perceptions of Foreigners in Singapore: There's a **distinction between highly-skilled 'foreign talent' and low-skilled 'foreign workers'**, including FDWs. This leads to a dichotomy in the way these groups are treated and perceived in society.
- Control and Social Quarantine: FDWs face control with **limited protection** and a form of **social quarantine**, which includes being barred from long-term social life, family formation, and restricted mobility.
- Singapore's Social Welfare and Self-Reliant Family Model: The state insists on a self-reliant family model, affecting its approach to migrant workers. Public housing and caregiving are examples where the state encourages **family units to manage their resources and care responsibilities**.
- Reforms and Their Limits: While there have been reforms to improve FDWs' working conditions, these changes prioritize employers' interests and maintain the self-reliant family model. The social quarantine of FDWs remains largely unaddressed.
- Implications for Understanding and Reform: The analysis suggests the need for a broader understanding of the state's positions in migration policies and their **interconnectedness with other social forces**. It highlights the importance of not reducing the issue to a simple employer-employee opposition, instead focusing on systemic conditions that create injustices.

Key Examples and Elaborations

- FDWs' Working Conditions: Examples include wages, rest days, and living conditions that are largely determined by individual employers, often leading to difficult and exploitative situations.

- Dichotomy of Foreign Workers: The contrasting treatment of high-skilled 'foreign talent' and low-skilled 'foreign workers', including FDWs, creates a societal division. High-skilled foreigners are integrated into Singaporean society, whereas low-skilled workers face **social segregation and limited rights**.
- Challenges in Reforming Policies: Efforts to improve FDWs' conditions are **constrained by the overarching priority of maintaining the self-reliant family model** and the economic implications of such reforms.
- State's Role in Social Welfare and Family Model: Singapore's policies around public housing and caregiving emphasize the self-reliant family model, impacting the approach towards FDWs. This model promotes in-house care over institutional or external solutions.
- NGOs' Impact on Policy Change: The document acknowledges the role of NGOs in advocating for FDWs' rights, despite the state's reluctance to recognize their influence fully. It points out the gradual changes resulting from these advocacy efforts.
- This analysis provides a comprehensive understanding of how Singapore's approach to family and social welfare policies **influences its migration policies**, particularly concerning foreign domestic workers. It highlights the complexities and challenges in reforming these policies, considering the broader social and economic context.

The document "Topic 5: Teo and Piper" is extensive and covers a range of issues related to migration and family policies in Singapore, with a focus on the treatment of foreign domestic workers (FDWs). Here are additional examples and elaborations from the document:

- Different Categories of Migrant Workers: The document discusses the contrasting treatment of 'foreign talent' and 'foreign workers'. 'Foreign talent' are highly skilled professionals who are integrated into Singaporean society, whereas 'foreign workers', including FDWs, face social segregation and limited rights. For example, male foreign workers are often employed in the construction industry and live in hostels near but not in neighborhoods, while female domestic workers are confined to individual households with limited mobility outside of these units.
- Control with Limited Protection: Foreign workers on work permits, especially FDWs, face **strict control and surveillance with limited protection under Singaporean labor laws**. They are specifically **excluded from the Employment Act**, which governs work hours, rest, and wages for local workers. This exclusion situates them within the private sphere of individual households and limits their rights as workers.
- Social Quarantine and Suppression of Family Formation: The document introduces the concept of 'social quarantine', where work permit holders, particularly FDWs, are kept separate from Singaporeans in their everyday lives and barred from certain forms of social life, such as family formation. This is evident in the stringent rules for FDWs, who undergo bi-annual medical examinations to test for HIV and pregnancy, reflecting the state's perception of them as temporary workers without long-term stakes in Singaporean society.
- Singapore's Social Welfare and Self-Reliant Family Model: The state emphasizes a self-reliant family model in its social policies, which has implications for its approach toward migrant workers. Public housing and caregiving policies are examples where the

state **encourages family units to manage their resources and care responsibilities independently**, often relying on domestic workers. This is contrasted with the ideal of a self-reliant family, which is dependent on employed help yet **maintains the myth of self-reliance**.

- Reforms and Their Limits: Despite recent reforms aimed at improving FDWs' working conditions, such as the introduction of standard contracts and direct salary payment into bank accounts, the fundamental issues of voluntary compliance and flexibility for individual employers remain. The reforms emphasize employers' interests, maintaining the self-reliant family model, and leave the social quarantine of FDWs largely unaddressed.
- Contextual Analysis of Policies: The document argues for a **holistic understanding of state policies**, suggesting that critical analyses must consider a range of social forces and conflicting goals embedded within policies. This includes recognizing how **systemic conditions produce injustices** and the need for reforms that do not pit employer and employee interests against each other.

These examples from the document highlight the complexities and challenges in reforming policies related to foreign domestic workers in Singapore, given the broader social and economic context. The analysis underscores the interconnectedness of migration and family policies and the need for a comprehensive approach to address these issues.

Feedbacks

Clip 1. Introduction: Early Migration into Singapore (Terence Heng)

- Case of Thian Hock Keng Temple as a symbol of migration and the importance of Chinese huay kuan (clan associations) as sources of social support and network
- 3 broad issues: (a) Migration is **not a new phenomenon**; (b) Racial discrimination more than discriminating persons on the basis of physical characteristics, but the way they dress; (c) There are ways to improve situations to make Singapore a more inclusive society
- Social media and technology used to **educate individuals on diversity**

Clip 2. Theories of Migration (Terence Heng)

- Founding of Singapore: Parameswara (Tan Sri Buana) and founding of Temasek (Singapura) based on Malay Annals; Raffles and Farquhar (in 1819) for economic and political opportunities
- Migration as the movement of individuals from one territory to another – for **economic, social, cultural and political reasons (push and pull factors)**
- Bauman: 2 distinct categories of migrants – (a) “vagabonds” (financially poor migrants and involuntary – for political reasons of fear of persecution, war or poor economic conditions); (b) high wage workers
- Four models as guiding categories: (a) classical model – e.g. expatriates; (b) colonial model; (c) guest-worker model – e.g. foreign workers; (d) illegal model – where you could see a blending of the different models in Singapore

Clip 3. Migration, Race and Ethnicity (Terence Heng)

- Issues of migrants and relationship with host society – and models of assimilation and integration
- Assimilationist model – further broken down into **classical model** (originating from 1920s US; and that adoption of the values and culture of the host society are slowly adopted through language, marriage, etc. and emergence of hybrid culture – e.g. Peranakans in Singapore); **racial or ethnic disadvantage model** (migrants unable to assimilate fully because of ethnic differences and barriers to integration based on structural, economic or social factors); and **segmented assimilationist model** (certain economic barriers mean that certain members of migrant group may be harder to assimilate as compared to others)

Clip 4. On the Sikh Diaspora in Singapore

- Interview with developers of Singapore Sikh Heritage Trail (Ishvinder Singh Sandhu and Vithya Subramaniam) and the interest in developing the app and memories
- Understanding Sikhs beyond their roles as guards and in security/police, and their participation in Singapore as also those involved in commercial enterprise (textiles and spice trade)
- Processes of integration of Sikhs and the larger community (through the open kitchen in the gurdwara/Sikh temple that is open to any Singaporean; links with other communities; etc.)
- Gurdwara as a site to assist integration of Punjab migrants

Clip 5. Online Media and Migrants (Terence Heng)

- How do we treat and react to migrants? Are the differences in treatment based on the country of origin? Consider the racial and ethnic disadvantage model; and the role race and ethnicity plays in regard to social integration in Singapore.
- Racial stereotypes and the entrenchment of racial model as **decidedly visual**, and although race is a social construct, given that it is not fixed, this remains relevant and powerful
- Centrality of online visual and social media – often based on quick and unfounded claims based on migrant differences and **perceived racial characteristics that grow into structural prejudice and marginalisation that can be fostered online**
- Individuals can be vehement against migrants, but there are some like **Healthserve** founded in 2006 to assist disadvantaged migrant workers through case work, health care and bridge communities etc.

Clip 6. Video on One Street Away (Healthserve)

- Experiences of foreign migrant workers in Singapore, motivations for coming, tribulations and struggles they face in Singapore; etc.
- Vulnerable population as an unskilled, low income worker; illegality at the workplace executed by employers
- Healthserve and their different roles and services directed to foreign workers; and engaging with communities

Clip 7. Conclusion (Terence Heng)

- Migration as a complex process involving different experiences, memories and journeys

Clip 8. Liveability (Charles Carroll)

- Broad Context: UN-Habitat world population statistics show that there has been more people who live in cities globally (from 1/3 in 1950 to 1/2 in 2000 to 2/3 projection in 2050); 400 cities worldwide have a population of more than 1 million
 - Liveability needs to consider **population density**, which is highly relevant to Asia –2,000-12,000 people per sq. km, including Singapore
 - A popular thought is that an increase in population density will have a negative effect on liveability – overcrowding and congestion; social and environmental problems; poverty; crime; pollution; high cost of living; etc.
 - Highly built up cities are shaped and **challenged by several factors**: shifts in population and demography; transformation of housing needs; changing energy costs; and transformations of technology. These are compounded in Singapore by limitation of size – crucial to the survival of the Singapore state (as well as the increase in population density historically)
 - Importance and challenges of developing a liveable city in SG include considering the key aspects of a liveable city; efforts in planning and developing a liveable city; as well as role of individuals and organisations
- Video Clip: Centre for Liveable Cities (URA)
- Liveable city has a **competitive economy, high quality of life and sustainable environment**
 - Requires two levers: (a) Planning and development that is integrated and longterm; (b) dynamic Governance (that is visionary and pragmatic)
 - Community as stakeholders, and work with the market, balancing public service with private sector
 - Adopts a holistic and forward-looking framework for land use and master planning

Interview with Liu Thai Ker (LTK)

- How do we make cities liveable? Importance to consider people (plan to satisfy the **fundamental needs of daily living** – jobs, housing, transportation, schools, amenities, location (schools, police station, hospitals, etc.) and land (good infrastructure provisions for cities to function – forests, rivers, transport, etc.)

Clip 9. What Makes Singapore Successful as a Liveable City

Interview with Wong Mun Summ (WMS)

- Singapore, **good governance, and the provision of good infrastructural facilities** (before buildings and before people move in) and **affordable good social housing**
- The establishment of a **walkable city**, bringing to the planning footpaths and connections; making Singapore a clean, green and garden city
- New typologies being built which offer **connectedness** (e.g. Skyville@Dawsonresidential complex, units/villages connected with intermediate sky gardens, interview with resident on experiences living there, Caroline Chan, Robin Koe, Gina Soon, Royce Fam – increased chances to interact with neighbours)

Interview with Liu Thai Ker

- Good governance, strategies, planning
- Creation of high-density cities and **neatness** of architecture/buildings
- Environments which make people feel oppressive include not being able to see the sky in design. Therefore, he employed the idea of the **Western chessboard** as part of the

design planning, mixing and alternating high density with low density buildings (to see the sky) as part of the overall master plan

How have city planning ideas transformed?

- WMS: Design of cities (in the 1990s) are now generally outdated principles and strategies of city planning for vehicles (glorified the automobile – very parcellated city and people placed second to vehicles). For liveable cities **need to account for people moving and human connection, solutions to counter such directions.**
- LTK: **symptoms of backward cities** – dirty buildings, polluted air, flooding, traffic jams, no trees, etc. (cf. to Singapore's planning)

Clip 10. Challenges of Singapore as a Liveable City

- Climate change and increasing ageing population, with interviews with Liu Thai Ker, Wong Mun Summ and Fung John Chye (FJC)
- Climate Change
- LTK: Bigger cities need to take responsibility, given Singapore has not much influence on global warming issue, but government does take the lead to mitigate this (checking cars exhaust fumes, OTTV, provision of public transportation optimally, etc.)
- WMS: Not only think of people, but people wellbeing with nature; nature as part of the built environment; landscaping to cool the city and to mediate global warming

Ageing

- LTK: Need for master plan to address ageing issues and problems
- FJC: Ageing as **multifaceted issue and challenges** (ageing-in-place as the longterm sustainable model in providing long term care, cf. community-ageing-withplace – health care and social care and maintaining relationships). Lessons learnt from different societies are also important (e.g. Japan and provision of diversity of care from nursing homes, co-housing to assisted living; sense of community; etc.) though this cannot be transplanted in totality
- WHS: Kampung Admiralty as a case study for community-ageing-with-place

Challenges of maintaining SG as a liveable city in the next 50 Years

- LTK: To understand **basic human needs and principles and reasons for success** - before innovation is successful
- WHS: Sustainability and to achieve self-sufficiency (energy, food, water, greenreplacement), footprint would shrink down in the city (if all cities do this)
- FJC: Neighbourhoods will evolve (smart-nation, technology) but value human-tohuman relationship and infrastructure to facilitate this (as societies become more open and experience more global disruptions)

Clip 11. Wishes for Singapore's Future

- LTK: Accumulated body of planning theory and strategies for younger generation planners (Need to be objective and reflect on the relevance of models from the West)
- FJC: Develop deep empathy for elderly and ageing, and cultivate set of core values
- WHS: Self-sufficient in next 50 years (for people and embracing nature and thriving ecosystem)

Aspirations and Identity

- Utopia is not just a narrative, but also an **aspiration**.
- It is paramount that Singapore put in place **futuristic policies** to help it maintain its competitive edge:
 - entrepreneurship
 - Spring Singapore established in 1996
 - the disruption to the economy can be too much if we continue to rely on MNCs
 - education
 - liberal arts education, broad-based education
 - something that makes you think
 - heritage
 - preservation of sites and monuments - historical importance
 - conservation - architecture and urbanism
 - public feedback will be constant input
- Singapore has adopted the philosophy of **economic pragmatism** since its independence.
 - pragmatism refers to meeting the needs and hopes of people at any point in time.
- Singapore is a **price taker** in the global market and therefore it needs to adopt pragmatism to seize opportunities for it to advance.
- **Survival and success are closely linked** in Singapore's context.
- Singapore success is **built on trust**.
- Singapore government needs to help Singapore attain the **political space and economic space**.
- Singapore had to **appreciate diversity** and create space for differences given our multiracial and multireligion composition.
- IQ + EQ + LQ
- New 5Cs
 - contribution, character, commitment, conviction, and community
 - creativity, collaboration, contribution, compassion and confidence
 - career, comfort, children, consideration and charity
- **shared values vs core values**
- CMIO framework is actually structurally creating the divide, results in overracialisation of a society. (Should we be still using this?)
- The way we are is influenced by the sense of how we were.

Reading: Multiethnicity in multicultural Singapore: critical autoethnography to understand racism in Singapore

Farah Bawany

"Topic 6: Bawany" is an autoethnographic article by Farah Bawany that delves into the experiences of a woman of color growing up in multicultural Singapore. The article chronicles Bawany's personal journey, reflecting on how her multi-ethnic background and the racial politics of institutionalized multiculturalism have shaped her life and identity. It brings to light the subtle and often **insidious ways hegemonic ideologies influence perceptions and experiences of ethnicity in a predominantly Chinese Singapore.**

- **Early School Experiences:** Bawany describes her first day at school, where she observes an 'Indian gap'—a physical distancing by Chinese girls from their Indian counterparts, revealing early instances of racial segregation and prejudice.
- **Racial Stereotypes:** She recounts hearing a racially offensive joke that crudely categorizes different ethnic groups by skin color, leading to her own traumatic attempt to alter her skin tone.
- **Language and Identity:** Bawany's experience in school highlights the challenges of navigating language and identity, where even her name is misinterpreted, revealing a **lack of cultural awareness and sensitivity from others.**
- **Cultural Disconnect:** Despite her proficiency in Malay due to her Indonesian heritage, she feels alienated in school, where her pronunciation of the language becomes a point of ridicule.
- **Educational Segregation:** Bawany reflects on her time at Cedar Girls Secondary School, noting the **implicit racial quotas that seemed to influence school placements**, contradicting Singapore's pledge of equality regardless of race, language, or religion.
- **Skin Color Prejudices:** Her experience with chickenpox leads to remarks on how her illness 'ruined' a classmate's 'porcelain skin', highlighting skin color biases.
- **Ethnic Identity:** Bawany discusses the complexities of her multi-ethnic background and how she **navigated various ethnic identities in school**, choosing to identify as Arab for social acceptance.
- **Internalized Racism and Colorism:** Despite advocating against colorism, she secretly uses skin-lightening products, revealing deep-seated issues of self-loathing due to societal beauty standards.
- **Relationships and Identity Politics:** She narrates her relationship with a Chinese boy, reflecting on the complexities of interracial and interfaith relationships in Singaporean society.
- **Struggle for Identity Acceptance:** Bawany shares her struggle for acceptance within the Arab community in Singapore, facing rejection due to not being 'Arab enough' and her challenges with cultural assimilation in a relationship with a Tamil family.
- **Future Generations and Self-Perception:** Pregnant with her first child, Bawany expresses a hope that her daughter inherits her father's lighter skin, highlighting her ongoing struggle with self-acceptance and the societal implications of skin color.

Concluding Reflections: Bawany concludes by emphasizing the deep-rooted and evolving nature of racial politics in Singapore. She stresses the need for **greater acknowledgment and understanding of diverse perspectives, particularly in academic settings, to challenge entrenched racial prejudices and stereotypes.**

The article is a poignant exploration of the personal impacts of racial and ethnic dynamics in Singapore, showcasing the **internal conflicts and societal challenges** faced by individuals of mixed heritage in a racially structured society. The document "Topic 6: Bawany" by Farah Bawany, offers a deeply personal and insightful view into the experiences of growing up as a woman of color in Singapore. Here are additional examples and elaborations from the document:

- **Childhood in School:** As a child in primary school, Bawany felt the sting of racial segregation. She recalls an instance where her and other girls of color were physically distanced by their Chinese classmates. This 'Indian gap' was a painful lesson in racial prejudice at a young age.
- **Dealing with Racial Stereotypes:** Bawany shares a memory of a hurtful joke that racially categorized Chinese, Malay, and Indian people based on skin color. This incident had such an impact on her that she attempted to alter her skin tone with her mother's razor, resulting in a lifelong scar.
- **Language and Cultural Confusion:** During her school years, Bawany experienced **confusion and misrecognition** due to language and cultural barriers. Her math teacher, for instance, used a term unfamiliar to her to get her attention, making her feel isolated and misunderstood.
- **Cultural Exposure and Alienation:** Bawany grew up listening to Bahasa Indonesia due to her family's history, which made her feel both connected to her heritage and alienated in school, where she was mocked for her pronunciation.
- **Secondary School Experience:** Bawany noticed a significant racial segregation in her secondary school, where despite scoring high enough for a more prestigious school, she and other girls of color were grouped in another school, suggesting implicit racial quotas in the education system.
- **Perception of Skin Color:** An incident where a teacher comments on a classmate's 'ruined porcelain skin' due to chickenpox, while ignoring her own discomfort, highlights the deep-seated biases and insensitivity towards darker skin tones.
- **Navigating Complex Ethnic Identity:** In school, Bawany had to navigate the complexities of her multi-ethnic background. Despite her diverse heritage, she chose to identify as Arab for social acceptance and to avoid certain prejudices she faced otherwise.
- **Internal Conflict and Colorism:** Despite publicly opposing colorism, Bawany **struggled with self-loathing due to societal beauty standards, resorting to using skin-lightening products in private.**
- **Interpersonal Relationships and Social Pressures:** She shares her experience of being romantically involved with a Chinese boy, reflecting on the **complexities of interracial and interfaith relationships in Singapore's societal context.**
- **Struggle for Acceptance in the Arab Community:** Despite finding initial acceptance in the Arab community, Bawany eventually faces rejection for not being 'Arab enough', which leads her to reflect on her own identity and the need for self-acceptance.
- **Pregnancy and Hope for the Future:** While pregnant, Bawany hopes her child will inherit her father's lighter skin to avoid the racial prejudice and self-loathing she endured.
- **Personal and Academic Reflection:** In the conclusion, Bawany reflects on the challenges of addressing deeply ingrained racial prejudices and the complexity of ethnic politics in

Singapore. She emphasizes the importance of **teaching and exposing students to diverse perspectives as a way to challenge and change entrenched racial stereotypes and biases.**

These examples from the document paint a vivid picture of the complexities and challenges of growing up and forming an identity in a multi-ethnic yet racially structured society like Singapore.

Feedbacks

Clip 1. Singapore as Utopia

- Visions of future Singapore and Singapore as a narrative – its **economic miracle** has led it to be thought of as a utopia (or ideal society; “good place” or “no place” – see also Thomas More’s novel)
- Utopia (T. More) as “good place” based upon a **perfect and efficient society** with habitats that are closely managed, targets set by leaders and people living harmoniously Garden of Eden (Lee) and from Third World to First World discourses have been invoked by state elites – commitment to these tropes often expressed during NDP and SG50 celebrations

Further information of the Garden of Eden metaphor:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jgvc_Zi_iC4&feature=youtu.be&t=34m50s

Interview with Viswa Sadasivan – best stability for society tied to an active citizenry and strong independent civil society

Clip 2. Charting Futures

- **Grabbing opportunities and the importance of planning** are principles undergirding Singapore’s policies and futuristic policies pertaining to entrepreneurship, education and heritage (through official narratives and visions)
- (a) Entrepreneurship and economic pragmatism
- Interview with Viswa Sadasivan and the role of MNCs – EDB and FDI at the very beginning of the economy and profit-maximisation and **no room for loyalty**; disruption to economy if overreliance of MNCs (for job opportunities, etc.)
 - Entrepreneurship entailing difficult situations – require specific desirable traits to be entrepreneurs
- (b) Education
- Emergence of a **liberal arts education framework** (Yale-NUS College and SUTD) and stimulation of critical thought and applying knowledge
 - Interview with PN Balji and broad-based liberal education – changing job markets and relevance of what is learnt in schools and entire industries/jobs disappearing
- (c) Heritage and planning
- Interview with Kelvin Ang – policies for preservation of buildings both looking at **aesthetic and pragmatic level**, managed by two sites – Preservation of Sites and Monuments (under Ministry of Culture) and Conservation (under URA) with different criteria to be eligible for conservation (e.g. identity to the area/state, etc.)
 - Public feedback on heritage as evolving and post-material needs and aspirations that have been changing (e.g. Rail Corridor project; Bukit Brown Cemetery)

Clip 3. The New 5Cs

- The construction of the ideal society and new, evolving private and collective aspirations of individuals and groups
- 5Cs defining the “Singapore Dream” and “the good life” – economic success trumping all other goals and aspirations with Generation X (born in 1960s-1980s) with **material aspirations coinciding with economic transition of Singapore**; with changing and redefined aspirations among millennial generation (born 1990s-2000s) where possession of **material goods not especially important**
- Surveys show having a healthy work-life balance is more important than a pay raise and promotion; and non-tangible causes as increasingly more important (e.g. giving back to society; animal welfare; inclusiveness; etc.)
- Interview with Melanie Chua and aspirations beyond purely material needs – fulfilment of material needs can now move toward other aspirations; and **shared values for diverse community** (but also vague notion especially about prioritising what is important)
- Interview with PN Balji – core values (universal) rather than shared values

Clip 4. Multiculturalism Redux

- Singapore as a **cosmopolitan city and the diverse ethnic and religious groups** have coexisted peacefully – so much so that the state of ethnic relations have been described as the “Garden of Eden State”
- Singapore’s brand of CMIO multiculturalism and the adequacy of the model to capture Singapore’s diversity – how aspirations are negotiated between policymakers and citizens – and an exercise in attempting to find a **common ground between collective and shared aspirations**
- Interview with Viswa Sadasivan – “Others” component has changed and morphed drastically with migration and inter-marriage; ethnic or national identity marker as more important, or is socioeconomic class status more important?
- Race as having diminished importance and distinctiveness of “Singaporean-ness” that is separate from Malaysia as well after **evolution of society**, but reminders of race entrenched in dominant discourses can heighten racialisation (e.g. self-help groups) of society which may come in the way of having a truly cohesive society
- Interviews with several undergraduates and others (Melissa Ang; Tan Tarn How) about the construction of a national identity and what identity markers are considered important; and the need to encourage debate (e.g. should we move beyond CMIO in the future and its future aspirations?)
- Interview with Viswa Sadasivan – management of superdiversity and that there is **no necessity for excessive state intervention for cohesiveness**

Clip 5. Back to the Future

- Cultural memory and collective imaginings of Singapore’s past (e.g. SG50 celebration); and visions of SG100 (in 2065)
- Transformation of the idea of the nation as an abstract form, rather than a physical space per se i.e. an imagined community
- **Singapore Stories (in the plural)** to account for diversities and other realms of possibilities in and for future Singapore

Clip 6. Interview with Lim Siong Guan (Part I)

- The ideology of pragmatism is organised to **meet the needs, hopes and aspirations** (for the future) of people at any particular point in time. The sense of what is good may change (from basic necessities and unemployment, to other aspirations)
- Security, survivalism and vulnerability have been reiterated to explain pragmatism (as well as attempts for Singapore to seize opportunities)
- Importance of **trustworthiness** to attract investment opportunities, as well as the treatment of race and religion as sensitive and visceral issues (recognize the importance of diversity and making space for one another, and the freedom to choose religion but to the extent that does not deny the freedom to another)
- To maintain peace and stability we **give up our freedoms and liberties in the name of harmony**, recognize and accept differences and provisions
- Branding of Singapore and ranking of nation-states
- Given Singapore's small size, it is important to **create political and economic space** and opportunities for Singapore in the international arena? To create economic space in the international arena
- How people choose governments is not fundamentally different from previously
- Race and religion will continue to matter in the future. The reason why there may not be any flare-ups is linked to Singapore's **sensitivity to take into account diversity** (which is good to create new ideas to serve the better good of most people)
- Important to consider how we treat and look out for each other and are **sensitized to our differences** when interacting with one another, especially given that there will always be **relative poverty**

Clip 7. Interview with Lim Siong Guan (Part II)

- Importance of **prioritising honour**: honoring our word (mutual worth and trustworthiness) – and honoring diversity to run a gracious society in all aspects of society
- Jack Ma's speech (NYU Shanghai Guest of Honour) – for new graduands to succeed, s/he needs high IQ, EQ (to spot opportunities), LQ (love quotient – looking out for and respecting people)
- **Government cannot deliver heart**, only human beings can do so with emotion and connect with one another.
- Global exposure for other cultures with advent of technology can be important to consider if ideas can work
- 3 reasons for failures (project, organization, etc.): **failure to learn** from the past (learn from other people failure); **failure to adapt** to the present (with environment change, demographic change, etc); and **failure to anticipate** the future (position to build capacity and strength with evolving future)
- Learn from successes and failures – make the judgment of whether this is important for Singapore – what is good for Singapore and the future
- Significance of delivering a gracious society in SingaporeSingaporeans aspirations of the future and what is important to them. Values and beliefs and how do we get there and what do we change. Covid-19 gives some optimism how to get there, but questioned the need a crisis for Singapore to reach its development potential.

